ROUTINES AND TRANSITIONS

Transitions and changes in routine are often challenging for young children because:

They have not yet developed a strong sense of time, so changes in typical routines make the world feel unpredictable

Adults often feel unsettled with changes in routine too

Routines are comforting because children learn to predict what will happen next

Keeping routines consistent makes the world feel safe, even if they push back (e.g., “I don’t want to go to bed!”)

Transitions between steps of the routine can be challenging because of this lack of awareness of time

Particularly when transitioning to less fun parts of the routine (e.g,. Playtime is over, bedtime)







ADAPTED FROM THE MOM POWER VIRTUAL GROUP CURRICULUM (MUZIK & ROSENBLUM ET AL., UNPUBLISHED MANUAL, 2021)

ROUTINES AND TRANSITIONS

STRATEGIES THAT CAN HELP WITH TRANSITIONS AND CHANGE IN ROUTINE INCLUDE:

Create an interactive routine chart

- Helps them build the habit of following a list
- Make it as engaging as you can (use stickers, magnets, dry erase boards, etc. so kids can "check off" each box when completed)
- Let them make a few choices about the routine chart (e.g., drawing pictures next to each step, coloring the chart, etc) to further increase their buy-in and motivation

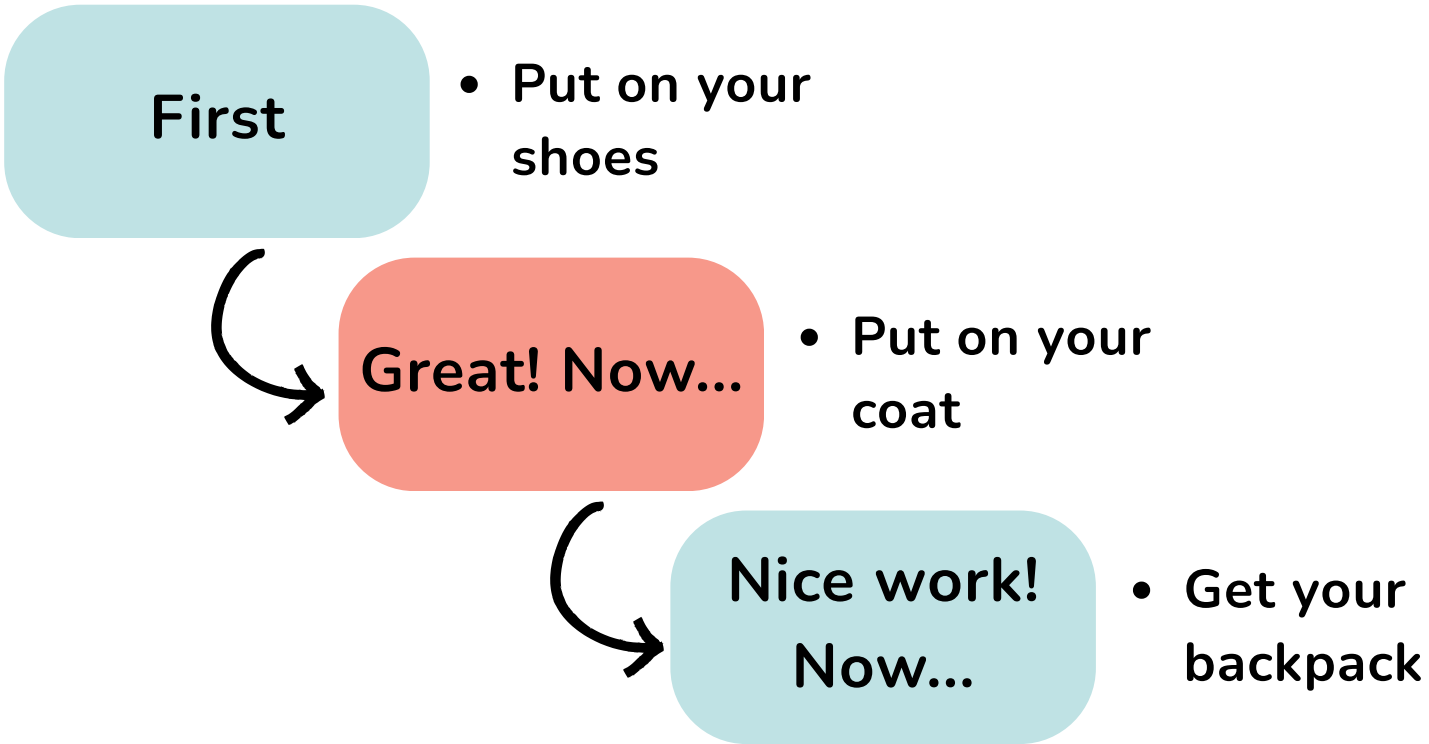
Morning	Night Time
☐ Brush teeth	☐ Brush teeth
☐ Pick an outfit	☐ Get into PJs
☐ Get dressed	☐ Bedtime story
☐ Eat breakfast	☐ Bedtime!

ROUTINES AND TRANSITIONS

STRATEGIES THAT CAN HELP WITH TRANSITIONS AND CHANGE IN ROUTINE INCLUDE:

Give one-step directions

- Break down requests into individual steps and only ask for the first step. Once the first step is completed, praise your child and then give the second step.
- Increases the likelihood that your child will be successful, which makes routines happier and easier for everyone
- Over time, test out your child's ability to follow two-step directions during familiar routines (morning, nighttime)



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ROUTINES AND TRANSITIONS

Timers and Reminders

Transitions often go smoother when children have multiple reminders before the change. This strategy helps them be aware of time passing and anticipate the transition before it happens. It can also decrease the risk of a big emotional reaction when the transition occurs.

Multiple reminders (5 min, 2 min, 1 min) tends to work best



Try having your child help you set timers with a physical timer, phone, or smart speaker



Visual timers often work particularly well for assessing time for young children



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